

Parent Guide — middle / module-02- panchabhuta

IKS Curriculum

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Parent Guide — Module 2: Panchabhūta (Five Elements)

Your child's age: Middle (Grades 6–8) · **Module length:** 10 sessions × 45 min over ~2 weeks

What your child is learning

The Sāṅkhya framework of *pañca-mahābhūta* — five categories Indian thinkers used to organise everyday matter and space:

Sanskrit	English
pr̥thvī	earth / solid
ap	water / liquid
tejas	fire / heat / light
vāyu	air / gas
ākāśa	space / room

Plus a deeper layer: - The **creation sequence** — how the five elements emerge one after another (space first, earth last). - The **quality-count rule** — each element inherits all qualities of the elements before it. - The **tanmātra mapping** — each element pairs with a perceptual quality (sound, touch, form, taste, smell).

How we teach it

The framing is **secular and scientific first**. We lead with what your child can observe, then situate the Sanskrit framework as one historical Indian way of organising that observation. We do NOT teach this instead of modern chemistry — we teach it as an additional intellectual framework.

NEP 2020 §4.6 (Integration of Indian Knowledge Systems) supports this approach.

Homework you'll see

- Bring 3 home objects to sort by element (Days 1, 4).
- Find a single thing that has “all five qualities” — e.g. soil, lemon, jaggery (Day 2).
- A 20-min walk in your neighbourhood to find an element “imbalance” (Day 7).

- A project — poster, demo, story, video, infographic, or song (Days 8–10).
- 6–10 writing prompts across the module (reflection, explanatory, argumentative, creative).

How to help

Helpful: - Quiz your child on the five Sanskrit names *gently*. They should know them by Day 5. - For the home walk, walk with them. Ask what they notice — don't tell them what to write. - For their project: provide materials and access to a source verse from the cache (see below) if they want to cite. - Discuss the Day 6 cross-disciplinary lesson: how does the modern periodic table relate to the five elements? Both are real. Both are useful. They answer different questions.

Not helpful: - Insisting “ancient Indians knew everything before science discovered it.” This framing isn't what we teach. - Doing the project. The struggle is the learning. - Pushing your child toward a “correct” position on Day 7's discussion. The point is engagement, not agreement.

Citation standard

By Middle band, projects must cite at least one verse from a primary source. The verses we use are from the Bhāgavata Purāṇa (specifically Cantos 2, 3, 4). The retrieved verses with translations are cached in `.rag-cache/` folders within the module pack — your child can show you the source they used.

This trains the habit: real citations from real texts, not invented references.

What success looks like

By end of module, your child can: - Name all 5 elements + 5 tanmātras + 5 senses in Sanskrit with English meaning. - Diagram the creation sequence. - Explain why earth has 5 qualities and space only 1. - Compare pañcabhūta with the modern states-of-matter framework fairly. - Present a 3-minute project on one element with a source citation.

On respect across traditions

Some students' families read these verses devotionally. The classroom frame is *both/and*: the verses are real scripture AND we use them here as historical primary sources. We avoid framing that diminishes or inflates either dimension.

Want to go deeper?

Senior band (Grade 9–12) covers the full 25-tattva Sāṅkhya enumeration and includes comparative work with Empedocles and Aristotle. Preview: [curriculum/senior/module-02-panchabhuta/README.md](#).

10-Day Lesson Plan

Module 2 (Middle) — 10-Day Lesson Plan

At a glance

Day	Session title	Lesson file	Activity / assessment
1	The Hook — Five Things Everywhere	days/day-01-hook.md	Sensory station rotation
2	Creation Sequence	days/day-02-creation-sequence.md	Diagram-build, exit ticket
3	Five Qualities and Five Senses	days/day-03-five-qualities.md	Quality-to-sense matching; formative quiz
4	Element Sort	days/day-04-element-sort.md	activities/activity-01-element-sort.md
5	Mid-module Check	days/day-05-mid-module-check.md	quizzes/formative.md (Part A)
6	Cross-disciplinary: States of Matter	days/day-06-cross-disciplinary.md	Compare-contrast worksheet
7	Group Work: Balance & Imbalance	days/day-07-group-discussion.md	activities/activity-03-element-walk.md debrief
8	Project Session 1: Plan	days/day-08-project-session-1.md	Project draft submitted
9	Project Session 2: Build	days/day-09-project-session-2.md	Project draft submitted
10	Final Assessment + Showcase	days/day-10-final-assessment.md	quizzes/summative.md + project

Pacing notes

- Days 1–3 are content-heavy. If your class needs a half-day buffer, split Day 3 across two sessions and roll Days 5–10 forward by one slot. Drop Day 6 if you must compress; it can be assigned as guided reading.
- Day 4’s element-sort activity benefits from advance setup — see the activity sheet for the 24-hour-ahead step (asking students to bring three “interesting” objects from home).

- Project work (Days 8–10) assumes you’ve decided pair vs. individual by Day 5.

Suggested running theme

Open each class with the same question on the board: **“Which element did you notice most yesterday — and why?”** Two students share for 30 seconds each. By Day 10 every student will have spoken at least twice. This builds the observation habit the module is designed to grow.

Formative vs. summative weight

- Formative quizzes (Days 3 and 5) are **not graded** — they are diagnostic. Use them to decide who needs scaffolding on Day 6.
- Summative quiz (Day 10) — see rubric in `assessments/rubric.md`. Combined with project, total 40 marks.

What students leave the module with

- A working five-element diagram in their notebook with their own examples.
- The five Sanskrit terms with meanings, in their own handwriting.
- One completed project artefact.
- The habit of noticing which elements dominate any given environment.

Homework

Homework — Module 2 Panchabhūta (Middle)

Homework tasks per day. None should take more than 25 minutes for a Middle-band student. Skip a day if it conflicts with another subject’s deadline.

Day 1 → Day 2

Task: Bring **three interesting objects from home** to class on Day 4. They should be small enough to fit on your desk.

Bonus: Which element does each object belong to?

Time: 5 min (deciding) + carrying the objects.

Day 2 → Day 3

Task: Find ONE thing in your home that perfectly demonstrates the “all five qualities” of *pṛthvī*. It should be something you can hear, touch, see, taste (or imagine the taste), and smell. Write 2 sentences naming the object and what each quality feels like.

Examples your classmates might pick: a sliced lemon, a piece of jaggery, a freshly cut carrot, a hand-made clay pot.

Time: 10 min.

Day 3 → Day 4

Task: For each of your three home-objects, figure out the **dominant element** and the **dominant tanmātra**. Write one line per object.

Format: Object → dominant element → dominant tanmātra

Example: Lemon → pṛthvī → gandha (smell) is strongest, but rasa (taste) is close behind.

Time: 10 min.

Day 4 → Day 5

No new homework. Use the time to finalise your project pair / individual decision and to start thinking about which element you want to focus on.

Day 5 → Day 6

Task: Submit your **project plan paragraph** in writing.

Format: one paragraph, 5–8 sentences, stating: which element, which format (poster / demo / story / video / infographic / song), and what audience will see/hear/feel.

Time: 15 min.

Day 6 → Day 7

Task: Open your school science textbook to the chapter on “Matter in Our Surroundings” (Class 9, Chapter 1) — or whatever your closest equivalent is. Read one section. Write a 1-paragraph note: *what would the pañcabhūta framework get right about this topic, and what would it miss?*

Time: 20 min.

Day 7 → Day 8

Task: Bring ALL project materials to tomorrow’s class. The build session starts immediately. Anything you forget cannot be retrieved during class time.

Bonus: Pick one of the five elements (not your project element) and identify one “imbalance” example near your home — a polluted drain (*ap*), a dusty lot (*pṛthvī*), a noisy intersection (*ākāśa+śabda*), etc. Be ready to share in Day 7’s group session.

Time: 10 min.

Day 8 → Day 9

Task: Finish at home what you couldn’t finish in class today. Tomorrow is for *refining*, not for *starting*.

Time: variable — but cap at 30 min, then stop and rest. Done-is-better-than-perfect.

Day 9 → Day 10

Task: Final touches. Make sure you have: - [] The artefact (poster / video file / printed story / etc.) - [] Your script or notes - [] A working version of your 3-minute presentation in your head

Time: 15 min.

After Day 10

No homework. Module is complete. Take a breath. (If your next module begins immediately, check that module’s README for prerequisite reading.)